

Real User Monitoring (RUM)

What it is, why it matters, and how it works — explained simply

What Happens Without RUM?

Backend monitoring (APM) can tell you everything happening on the server. But it has no idea what the person using the app is actually experiencing in their browser.

- Is the page loading slowly for real users?
- Are people clicking a button and nothing happens?
- Is a JavaScript error breaking the page silently?

None of these questions can be answered from the server side alone. That's the gap RUM fills.

What Is RUM, in Plain Terms?

RUM is a small piece of code that runs inside the browser, alongside the app. It quietly watches what happens on the page and reports it back — the same way a fitness tracker reports your steps without you doing anything extra.

It watches

Page loads, clicks, and background requests to the server.

It reports

Sends what it sees to Splunk Observability Cloud in real time.

It tags

Labels everything with the app's name, so it's easy to find.

The Four Things RUM Pays Attention To

Page Load

How long the page took to appear, from click to fully ready

Interactions

What the person clicked or tapped on the page

Network Calls

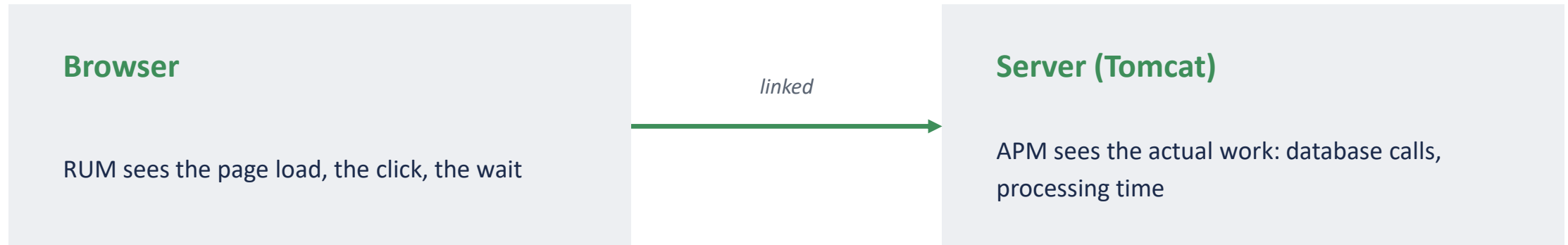
Requests the page made back to the server

Errors

JavaScript problems that break or glitch the page

Why RUM Alone Isn't the Whole Picture

A page can feel slow for two very different reasons: something in the browser, or something on the server. RUM alone can't tell you which — it just shows the symptom.



When the two are linked, a slow page in RUM can point straight to the exact backend moment that caused it.

What This Gives You Day to Day

Faster answers

Instead of guessing why a user complained, open their session and see exactly what happened.

Fewer blind spots

Frontend errors and slow loads no longer go unnoticed just because the server looked healthy.

One story, not two

The frontend experience and the backend cause show up together, not as separate puzzles.

The Idea in Three Sentences

Why

Backend monitoring can't see the browser — RUM fills that gap.

What

A lightweight script that watches page loads, clicks, calls, and errors.

How

It reports to Splunk Observability Cloud and links back to the backend trace.